INDIAN STATISTICAL INSTITUTE, BANGLORE CENTRE

DOCUMENTATION AND RESEARCH TRAINING CENTRE

COLLOQUIUM 1

SESSION 2025-2027

28 JANUARY 2026

TITLE- WHERE THEY BURN BOOKS, THEY BURN PEOPLE TOO

LIBRARIES AND GENOCIDE: THE PARALLEL DESTRUCTION

SPEAKERS:

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Fathima Nasreen
Greeshma KS
Madhu M
Rakendu S
Rasheedha Sulthana

COORDINATOR: **Dr.Biswanath Dutta**

INTRODUCTION

BBC NEWS. (2018, APRIL 25). RWANDA "GENOCIDE-ERA" MASS GRAVES FOUND. HTTPS://WWW.BBC.COM/NEWS/WORLD-AFRICA-43894989

GENO(S)CIDE

(GREEK) RACE

(LATIN) KILLING

GENOCIDE

In the present Convention, genocide means any of the following acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group, as such:

(a) Killing members of the group;

(b) Causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group;

(c) Deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part;

(d) Imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group;

(e) Forcibly transferring children of the group to another group. [1]

CHILDREN AT A REFUGEE CAMP

1. United Nations. (1948). Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide. In United Nations. https://www.un.org/en/genocideprevention/documents/atrocity-crimes/

GENOCIDE AS A SOCIAL PRACTICE

Genocidal social practice as a technology of power—a way of managing people as a group—that aims

1. to destroy social relationships based on autonomy and cooperation by annihilating a significant part of the population (significant in terms of either numbers or practices), and
2. to use the terror of annihilation to establish new models of identity and social relationships among the survivors[2]

2. Feierstein, D., & Town, D. A. (2014). Defining the concept of genocide. In Genocide as social practice: Reorganizing society under the Nazis and Argentina’s military juntas (pp. 11-38). Rutgers University Press.

SOURCE: RUSSIAN AMERICAN COMPANY (N.D.)

A GENOCIDE IS NEVER A SURPRISE.

A genocide happens in **stages,** but is **non-linear**. Dr. Gregory H. Stanton, President of Genocide Watch stated that *"Each stage is itself a process. Their logic is similar to a nested Russian matryoshka doll. Classification is at the center. Without it the processes around it could not occur. As societies develop more and more genocidal processes, they get nearer to genocide. "*

WHAT ARE THE STAGES?

Gregory H Stanton defined the 10 stages of a genocide.

1
CLASSIFICATION

The differences between people are not respected. There’s a division of ‘us’ and ‘them’.

2
SYMBOLISATION

This is a visual manifestation of hatred.

3
DISCRIMINATION

The dominant group denies civil rights or even citizenship to identified groups.

4
DEHUMANISATION

Those perceived as ‘different’ are treated with no form of human rights or personal dignity.

WHAT ARE THE STAGES?

Gregory H Stanton defined the 10 stages of a genocide.

5
ORGANISATION

Genocides are always planned. Regimes of hatred often train those who go on to carry out the destruction of a people.

6
POLARISATION

Propaganda begins to be spread by hate groups.

7
PREPARATION

Perpetrators plan the genocide. They often use euphemisms to cloak their intentions. They create fear of the victim group, building up armies and weapons.

8
PERSECUTION

Victims are identified because of their ethnicity or religion and death lists are drawn up. Genocidal massacres begin.

WHAT ARE THE STAGES?

Gregory H Stanton defined the 10 stages of a genocide.

9 EXTERMINATION	The hate group murders their identified victims in a deliberate and systematic campaign of violence.
10 DENIAL	The perpetrators or later generations deny the existence of any crime. [3]

3. Genocide Watch. (n.d.). Ten stages of genocide. https://www.genocidewatch.com/tenstages

CONNECT THE DOTS.

NOW WHAT?

What relevance does this have to us as Library professionals?

WHAT IS A LIBRARY?

- UNESCO (2020) defines library as an "Organisation, or part of an organisation, whose main aims are to build and maintain a collection and to facilitate the use of such information resources and facilities as are required to meet the informational, research, educational, cultural or recreational needs of its users; these are the basic requirements for a library and do not exclude any additional resources and services incidental to its main purpose.[4]

- The 'Library' as conceived by Pierce Butler, 'is a social organization' –necessary unit in the social fabric, effectively planned and organized for transmitting the accumulated experience of society to individual members of the society through the instrumentality of books and other graphic, acoustic and holistic materials – maps, charts, phono-records, microfilms, etc. [5]

4. UNESCO. (2020, June 22). Library. http://uis.unesco.org/en/glossary-term/library
5. Butler, P. (1933). An introduction to library science. University of Chicago Press.

NOW THE QUESTION ARISES,
WHY LINK LIBRARIES AND GENOCIDE?

"Culture must transcend the individual for it is essentially a social cumulation of experience whereby the men of each generation possess potentially at least, all that their predecessors have ever learned. Books are one social mechanism for preserving the racial memory and the library one social apparatus for transferring this to the consciousness of living individuals. Any understanding of society must include an explanation of this social element and of its function in communal life."

-Pierce Butler[5]

5. Butler, P. (1933). An introduction to library science. University of Chicago Press.

WHAT IS LIBRICIDE?

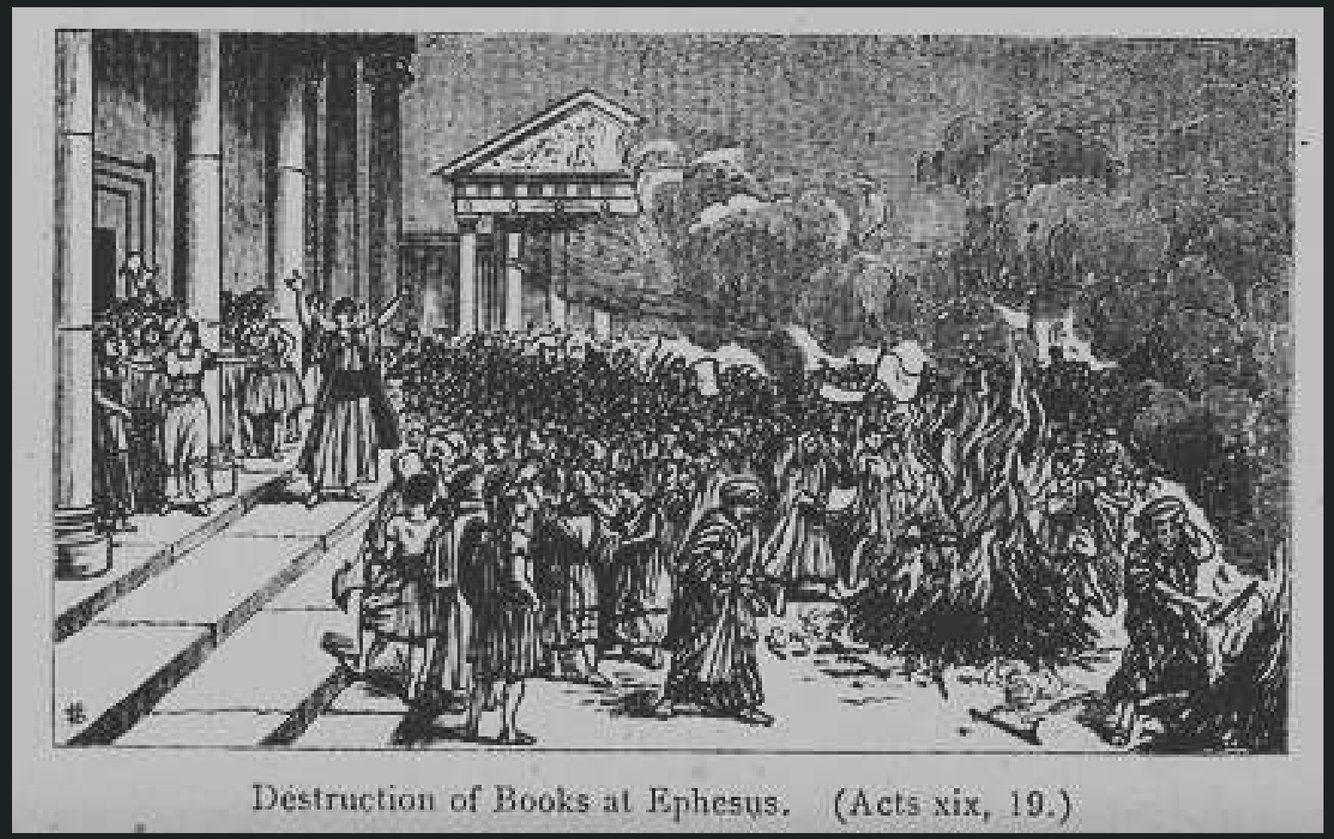
- Libricide is the intentional, systematic destruction of libraries as institutions rather than the incidental loss of books, a concept coined by Rebecca Knuth in the early 2000s to describe state-sanctioned and ideologically motivated attacks on recorded knowledge aimed at erasing collective memory, identity, and historical continuity.
- During armed conflicts, libricide has been used as a strategic weapon, most notably in the deliberate destruction of the Louvain University Library by German forces in 1914 and again in 1940, and the shelling and burning of the National Library of Bosnia and Herzegovina in Sarajevo in 1992, where libraries were targeted not for military value but to annihilate the cultural and historical presence of entire communities.[6]

6. Donovan, C. (2024). More than censorship: The harm of libricide.

“LIBRICIDE INTENDS TO ERASE COLLECTIVE MEMORY, TO INFLICT, IN THE WORDS OF POET TED HUGHES, ‘*ALZHEIMER’S IN THE NATION’S BRAIN*.’ [6]

6. Donovan, C. (2024). More than censorship: The harm of libricide.

WHY THIS TOPIC?



SOURCE: OPEN LIBRARY (2010)

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Greeshma KS	Libraries as sites of resistance and healing
Rakendu S	Ethics and Censorship
Fathima Nasreen	Conclusion

Spröer, S. (2023, August 23). How the Nazis burned first books, then people. dw.com. https://www.dw.com/en/how-the-nazis-burned-first-books-then-people/a-65518417

THE ARCHITECTURE OF ERASURE

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1. Metamorphosis
2. Targeting libraries: The Why?
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4. Legitimacy & Homogenization
5. Narratives
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7. Collective memory
8. The Holocaust: Case study
9. Fragmentation of Historical Consciousness

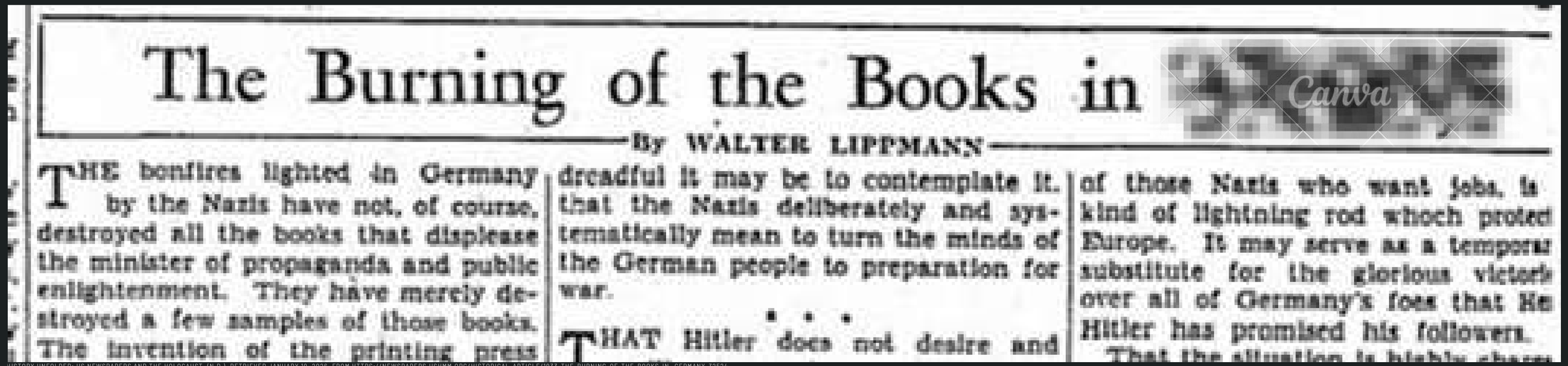
METAMORPHOSIS

‘Never before in the history of mankind has there been a century as destructive to books as the twentieth.’ [1]

INTENT [2]

1. Client challenge. (n.d.). https://www.scribd.com/document/473660214/Lost-Memory-Libraries-and-Archives-destroyed-in-the-20th-Century-1996-pdf
2. Valencia, Miriam. (2002). Libraries, Nationalism, and Armed Conflict in the Twentieth Century. Libri. 52. 1-15. 10.1515/LIBR.2002.1

TARGETING LIBRARIES: THE WHY?



The Burning of the Books in

By WALTER LIPPMANN

THE bonfires lighted in Germany by the Nazis have not, of course, destroyed all the books that displease the minister of propaganda and public enlightenment. They have merely destroyed a few samples of those books. The invention of the printing press

dreadful it may be to contemplate it. that the Nazis deliberately and systematically mean to turn the minds of the German people to preparation for war.

• • •

THAT Hitler does not desire and

of those Nazis who want jobs, is kind of lightning rod whoch protect Europe. It may serve as a tempora substitute for the glorious victor over all of Germany's foes that He Hitler has promised his followers.

HISTORY UNFOLDED: US NEWSPAPERS AND THE HOLOCAUST. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 19, 2026, FROM HTTPS://NEWSPAPERS.USHMM.ORG/HISTORICAL-ARTICLE/1933-THE-BURNING-OF-THE-BOOKS-IN- GERMANY-32524

SYMBOLIC ROLE OF LIBRARIES

Maintaining a national community over time and space is a key function of libraries, and when this function is interrupted by conflict, the ability of the community to recover its identity and cohesion is compromised. [3]

Libraries are destroyed because books and libraries preserve and provide witness to multi-ethnic memory, store evidence of the validity of a multitude of perspectives, and facilitate intellectual freedom and open discussion.[4]

3. Harpham, B. (2009). „The sun was obscured by the smoke of books“: libraries and memory institutions in conflict since the end of the Cold War. In Faculty of Information, University of Toronto, Faculty of Information Quarterly (Vol. 1, Issue 3, pp. 1–13).
4. Üngör, U. Ü. (n.d.). Cultural genocide. In cultural genocide: Destruction of material and non-material human culture.

LEGITIMACY & HOMOGENIZATION

Löwenthal distinguishes three main aims and functions of book burning:

1. The extinction of history
2. Acts of Purification
3. Liquidation of Subject [5]

Pandagolik. (n.d.). 21,300+ fascism stock photos, pictures & Royalty-Free Images - iStock. Retrieved January 19, 2026, from https://www.istockphoto.com/photos/fascism

5.German Commission for UNESCO. (2016). Proceedings of the conference held at the KU Leuven 9-11 September 2015 (Mel Collier, Ed.) [Conference-proceeding]. University Library, KU Leuven. https://www.goethe.de/resources/files/pdf94/streamgate.pdf

NARRATIVES

The destruction of library and archives is designed to destroy the claims of a group in two ways:

1. Pragmatic course
2. Destroying collective memory [2]

> **“[H]OW COULD YOU MAKE APPEAL TO THE FUTURE WHEN NOT A TRACE OF YOU, NOT EVEN AN ANONYMOUS WORD SCRIBBLED ON A PIECE OF PAPER, COULD PHYSICALLY SURVIVE?”**
>
> (ORWELL, 1989)

2. Valencia, Miriam. (2002). Libraries, Nationalism, and Armed Conflict in the Twentieth Century. Libri. 52. 1-15. 10.1515/LIBR.2002.1

BOSNIAN GENOCIDE

1992-1995

The Sarajevo Oriental Institute was targeted on 17 May 1992.
Shelling of the National and University library of Bosnia and Herzegovina on 25/26 August 1992.
' Losses included 5,263 bound manuscripts in Arabic, Persian, Hebrew and aliamiado, dating back to the Middle Ages; an archive of 7,000 Ottoman documents, primary source material for five centuries of Bosnia's history; a collection of cadastral registers from the last century of Ottoman rule in Bosnia, documenting the orginal land-owners; and 200,000 other documents of the Ottoman period, many of them microfilm copies of originals in private hands or obtained on exchange from foreign institutions.' [6]

NATIONAL AND UNIVERSITY LIBRARY OF BOSNIA AND HERZEGOVINA

Burgess, A., & Burgess, A. (2020, February 21). Harvard librarian puts this war crime on the map. Harvard Gazette. Retrieved January 17, 2026, from https://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2020/02/harvard-librarian-puts-this-war-crime-on-the-map/

6. Riedlmayer, A. (1994). KILLING MEMORY: THE TARGETING OF LIBRARIES AND ARCHIVES IN BOSNIA-HERZEGOVINA. MELA Notes, 61, 1-6. http://www.jstor.org/stable/29785597

"THE DESTRUCTION OF THE LIBRARY CAN ONLY BE SEEN AS AN ASSAULT ON THE CULTURE OF THE PEOPLE OF SARAJEVO, AN ATTEMPT TO DEPRIVE US OF OUR HISTORY, AS IF SUDDENLY WE HAVE BECOME A PEOPLE WITHOUT A PAST.”

HATIDZA DEMIRO, LIBRARIAN [6]

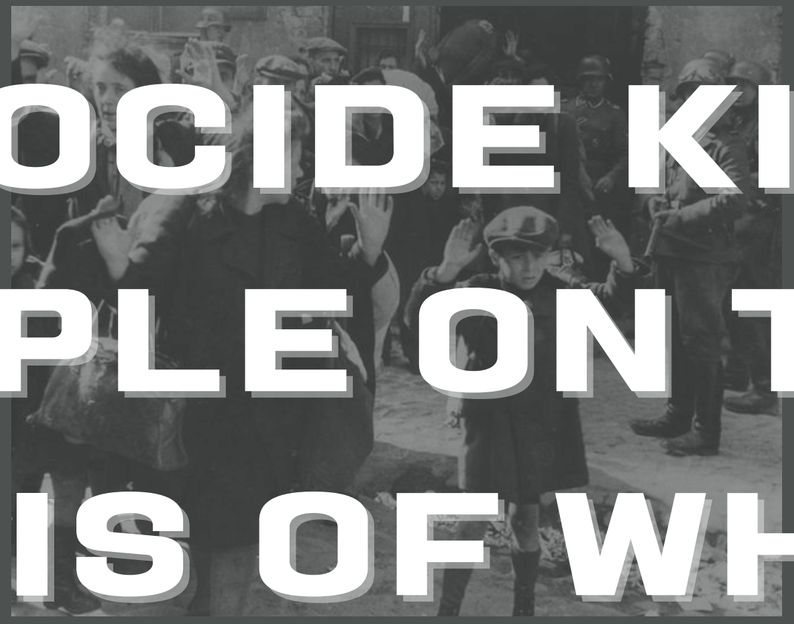
6. Riedlmayer, A. (1994). Killing memory: The targeting of libraries and archives in Bosnia- Herzegovina. MELA Notes, 61, 1-6. http://www.jstor.org/stable/29785597

COLLECTIVE MEMORY

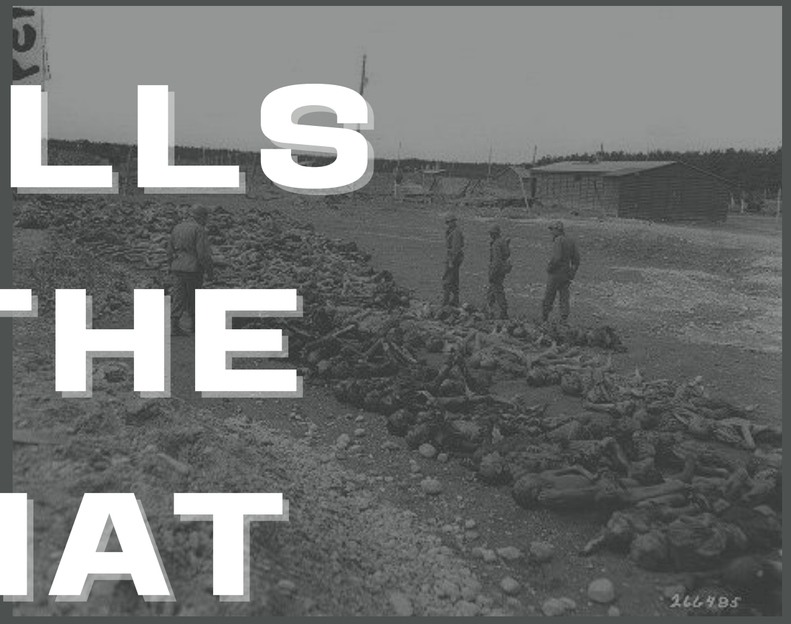
Cultural artifacts are an enormously important symbolic resource that strengthens the feeling of belonging and cohesion of a community, and provides a united symbolic repertoire that simultaneously distinguishes a given group from others. Cultural artifacts can, with the aid of memory, ritual, and mythos, establish or revive continuity with past generations. [7]

7. PARZINGER, H. (2022). CULTURAL HERITAGE UNDER ATTACK: LEARNING FROM HISTORY. IN CULTURAL HERITAGE AND MASS ATROCITIES. GETTY PUBLICATIONS. HTTPS://WWW.GETTY.EDU/PUBLICATIONS/CULTURAL-HERITAGE-MASS-ATROCITIES/DOWNLOADS/PAGES/CUNOWEISS_CHMA_PART-1- 03-PARZINGER.PDF

GENOCIDE KILLS PEOPLE ON THE BASIS OF WHAT THEY ARE, NOT WHO THEY ARE.[8]



BBC News. (2020, July 10). Bosnia's Srebrenica massacre 25 years on - in pictures. Retrieved January 18, 2026, from https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-53346759



Taylor, A. (n.d.). World War II: the Holocaust. The Atlantic. https://www.theatlantic.com/photo/2011/10/world-war-ii-the-holocaust/100170/

Concentration camps, 1942-45 - Photograph | Holocaust Encyclopedia. (n.d.). Holocaust Encyclopedia. Retrieved January 18, 2026, from https://encyclopedia.ushmm.org/content/en/gallery/concentration-camps-1942-45-photographs

6. Card, C. (2003). Genocide and Social Death. Hypatia, 18(1), 63–79. http://www.jstor.org/stable/3811037

Marshall, J. (2013, January 4). Ethics Dunces: The Videogame Burners of Southington, Conn. Ethics Alarms. Retrieved January 27, 2026, from https://ethicsalarms.com/2013/01/04/ethics-dunces-the-videogame-burners-of-southington-conn/

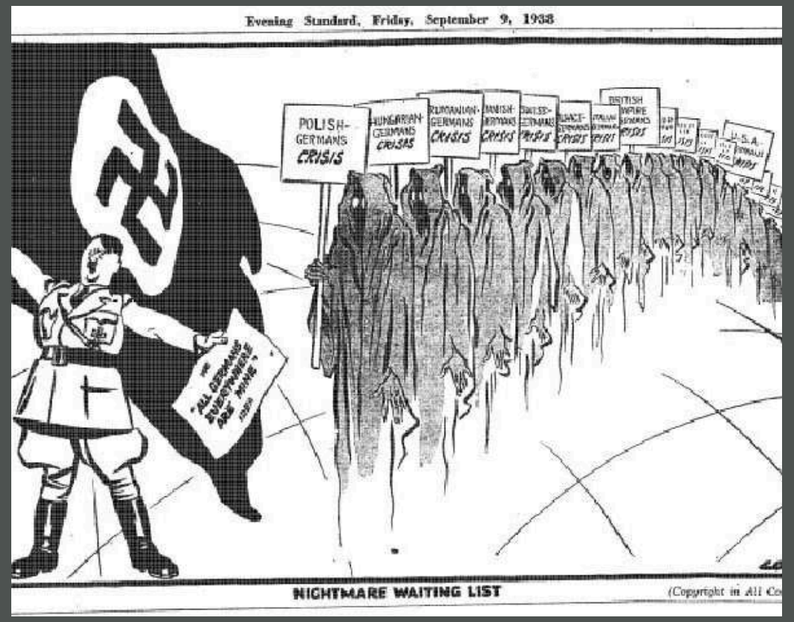
THE HOLOCAUST

1933–1945

'Book-burnings were symbolic of the whole Nazi world-view, in that the destruction of un-German' literature was seen as necessary in the Darwinian struggle to protect German culture.' [2]

After the Nazi seizure of power, a number of public library officials prepared black list of prohibited authors, amounting to 10% of library collections. [1]

Valencia, Miriam. (2002). Libraries, Nationalism, and Armed Conflict in the Twentieth Century. Libri. 52. 1-15. 10.1515/LIBR.2002.1



Land, G. (n.d.). 10 Famous Anti-Nazi Cartoons by David Low. History Hit. Retrieved January 27, 2026, from https://www.historyhit.com/culture/anti-nazi-david-low-cartoons/

nsdoku münchen - Book burnings 1933. (n.d.). Retrieved January 19, 2026, from https://www.nsdoku.de/en/historic-site/koenigsplatz/book-burnings-1933

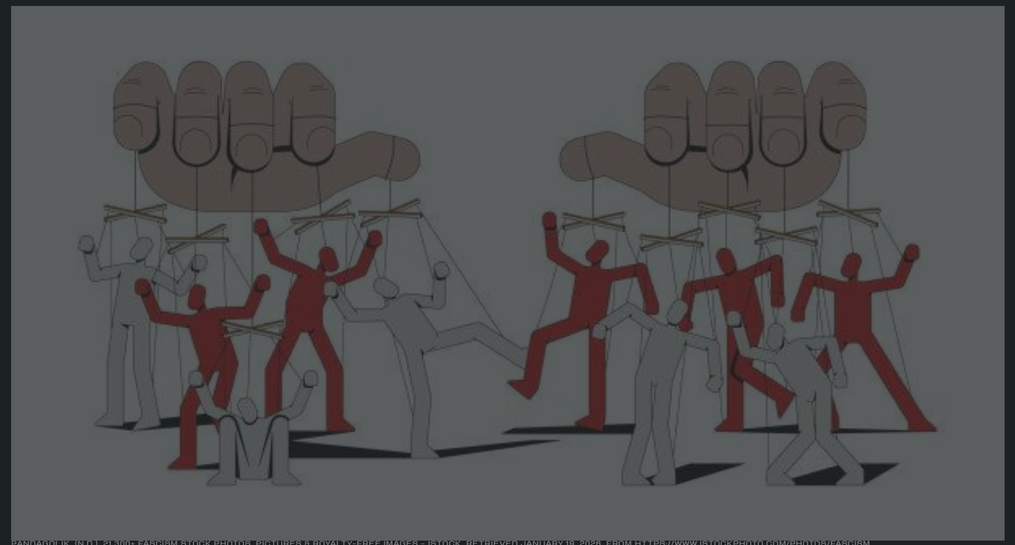
Holocaust Memorial Day Trust. (2019, May 3). 6 May 1933: Looting of the Institute of Sexology - Holocaust Memorial Day Trust. Retrieved January 19, 2026, from https://hmd.org.uk/resource/6-may-1933-looting-of-the-institute-of-sexology

"DESTROYING THE CULTURAL INSTITUTION THAT CARRIES PEOPLE'S IDENTITY IS LIKE DESTROYING THE PEOPLE THEMSELVES.” [9]

9. Moustafa, L. H. (2016). Cultural Heritage and Preservation: Lessons from World War II and the Contemporary Conflict in the Middle East. The American Archivist, 79(2), 320–338. http://www.jstor.org/stable/26356665.

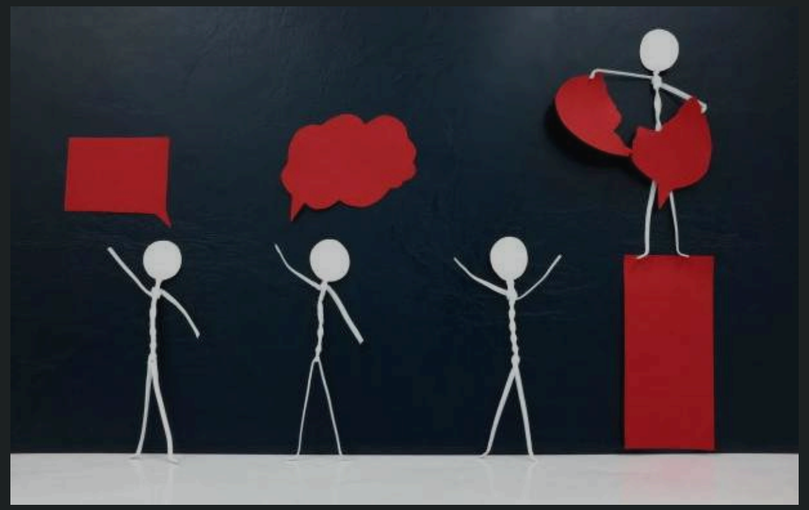
FRAGMENTATION OF HISTORICAL CONSCIOUSNESS

‘AS INSTITUTIONS THAT SUPPORT CULTURE THROUGH COLLECTIONS, LIBRARIES PROVIDE ARTIFACTS AND CONCRETE TESTIMONY THAT ALLOW INSIGHT INTO THE INTELLECTUAL AND SPIRITUALWORLD OF OUR PREDECESSORS AND, THUS, AID OUR UNDERSTANDING OF THE EVENTS OF HISTORY.’ [10]



PANDAGOLIK. (N.D.). 21,300+ FASCISM STOCK PHOTOS, PICTURES & ROYALTY-FREE IMAGES - ISTOCK. RETRIEVED JANUARY 19, 2026, FROM HTTPS://WWW.ISTOCKPHOTO.COM/PHOTOS/FASCISM

10. Knuth, R. (2003b). Libricide. In Praeger eBooks. https://doi.org/10.5040/9798400679308



Pandagolik. (n.d.). 21,300+ fascism stock photos, pictures & Royalty-Free Images - iStock. Retrieved January 19, 2026, from https://www.istockphoto.com/photos/fascism

“

Fernando Ba´ez writes that a Book is an *institution of memory*, and they are destroyed not as a physical object but as links to memory.
‘At the root of book destruction is the intent to induce historical amnesia that facilitates control of an individual or a society.’ [11]

11. Garrett, J. (2009). Why Burn a Library? [Review of Books on Fire: The Destruction of Libraries throughout History; Burning Books and Leveling Libraries: Extremist Violence and Cultural Destruction; A Universal History of the Destruction of Books: From Ancient Sumer to Modern Iraq, by L. X. Polastron, J. E. Graham, R. Knuth, F. Báez, & A. MacAdam]. The Library Quarterly: Information, Community, Policy, 79(4), 489-493. https://doi.org/10.1086/605386

“WEAPONISATION OF INFORMATION AND SYSTEMIC ERASURE OF KNOWLEDGE AND MEMORY”

IMAGE SOURCE : HEEDAYAH LOCKMAN (2025)

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   CENSORSHIP
   INTERNET BLACKOUTS

GENOCIDE

RACE KILLING

THERE COULD BE VARIOUS REASONS

- PROPAGANDA
- NARRATIVES
- POWER

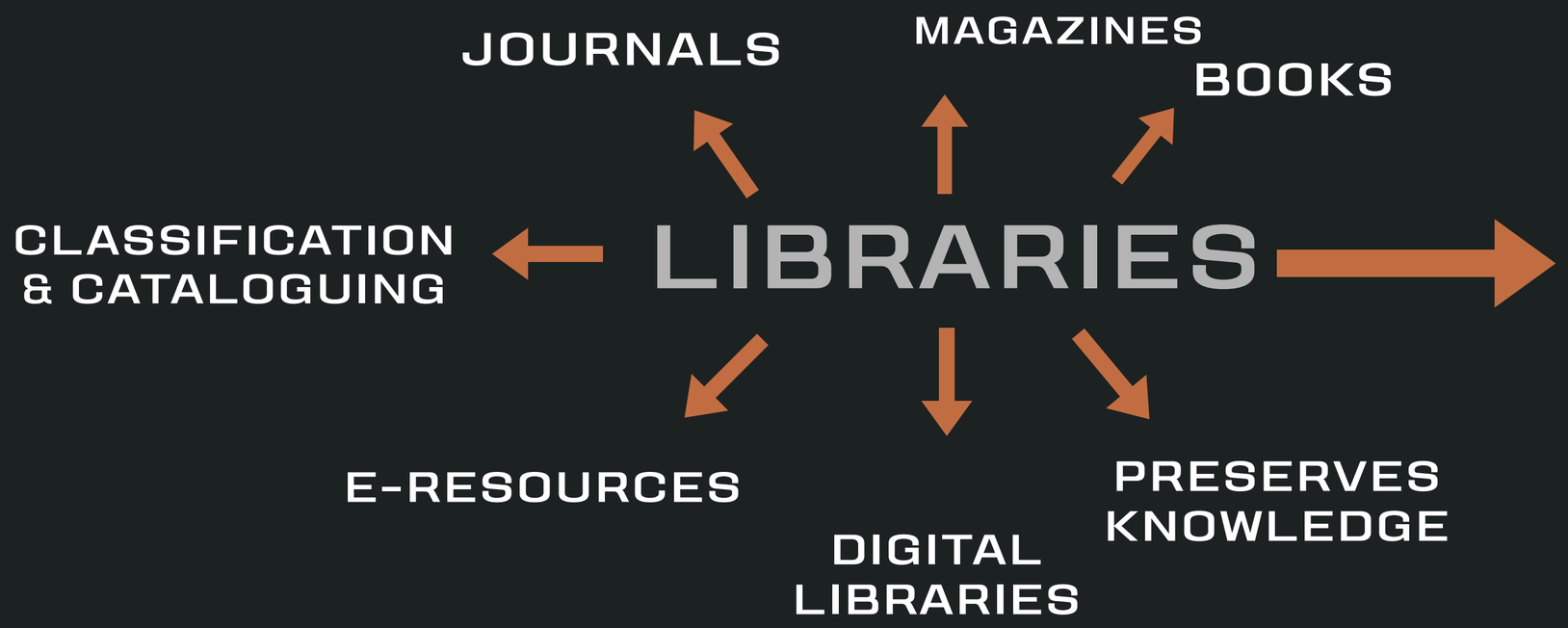
BUT, WHY TARGET LIBRARIES?

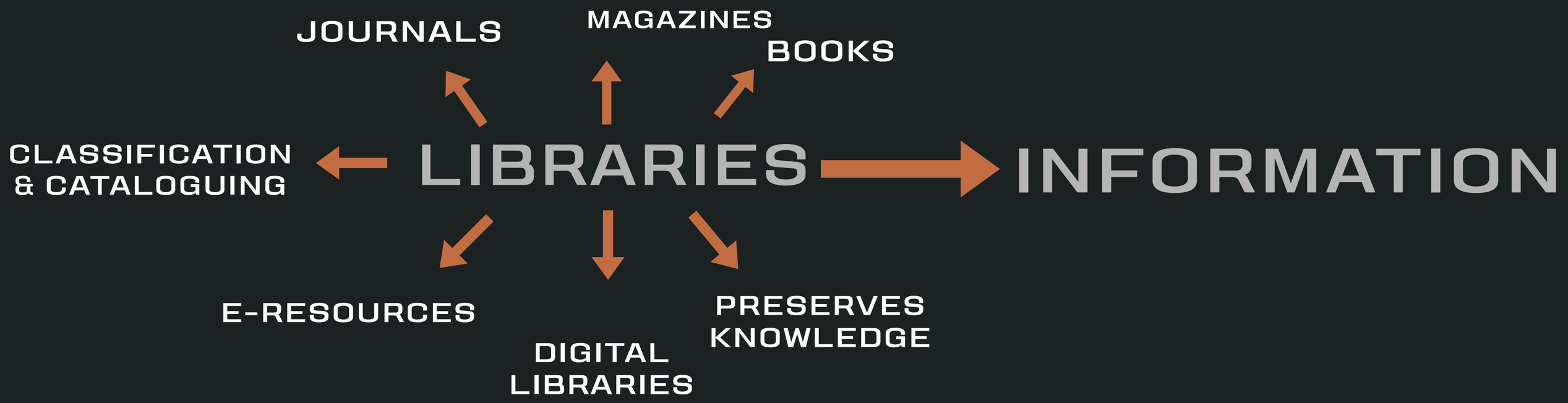
BECAUSE, IF YOU WANT TO BURN PEOPLE, BURN THEIR BOOKS

BOOKS = COLLECTIVE MEMORY, HISTORIES, LITERATURE,
MEDIUM OF CHANGE AGAINST STATE QUOISM

ONLY SOURCE OF PRESERVED HISTORY

LIBRARIES [1]


JOURNALS
MAGAZINES
BOOKS
CLASSIFICATION & CATALOGUING
LIBRARIES
E-RESOURCES
DIGITAL LIBRARIES
PRESERVES KNOWLEDGE


JOURNALS
MAGAZINES
BOOKS
CLASSIFICATION & CATALOGUING
LIBRARIES
INFORMATION
E-RESOURCES
DIGITAL LIBRARIES
PRESERVES KNOWLEDGE

VULNERABILITY?

VULNERABILITY?

WHAT ARE WE MOST VULNERABLE FOR, AT THIS POINT OF TIME?

VULNERABILITY?

WHAT ARE WE MOST VULNERABLE FOR, AT THIS POINT OF TIME?

OUR PERCEPTION OF THE WORLD

VULNERABILITY?

WHAT ARE WE MOST VULNERABLE FOR, AT THIS POINT OF TIME?

OUR PERCEPTION OF THE WORLD

HOW IT IS SHAPED?

VULNERABILITY?

WHAT ARE WE MOST VULNERABLE FOR, AT THIS POINT OF TIME?

OUR PERCEPTION OF THE WORLD

HOW IT IS SHAPED?

INFORMATION[2]

100 YEARS AGO

THE CHEMISTS’ CLUB LIBRARY IN NEW YORK, NEW YORK, CA. 1920.

TODAY

ELECTRONIC-DEVICES

LIBRARIES NOT ONLY DEAL WITH BOOKS
BUT MORE WITH INFORMATION

↓

TWEAK / IGNORE / ERASE INFORMATION

↓

AN INCIDENT, A COMMUNITY, A COLLECTIVE MEMORY

↓

REWRITING INFROMATION IN PEOPLE’S MEMORY

↓

[3]

INFORMATION GENOCIDE = INFOCIDE

SYSTEMIC ERASURE

“

ERASURE IS NOT AN INCIDENTAL LAPSE IN COLLECTIVE MEMORY BUT A STRUCTURED PROCESS SHAPED BY SOCIAL, INSTITUTIONAL, AND CULTURAL GATEKEEPING. [4]

– EVLONDO COOPER (2025) IN "RETRIEVAL LOST TO TIME: A TYPOLOGY OF STRUCTURAL ERASURE IN INTELLECTUAL AND POLITICAL MEMORY".

SYSTEMIC ERASURE

- SYSTEMIC DISCRIMINATION
- SYSTEMIC VIOLENCE
- SYSTEMIC SILENCE
- SYSTEMIC BIAS
- SYSTEMIC DENIAL
- SYSTEMIC EXCLUSION

[5] [6]

WEAPONISATION OF INFORMATION

“

“WEAPONS” REFERS TO INFORMATION DELIBERATELY USED AS A POWERFUL TOOL TO ACHIEVE SPECIFIC GOALS. THE INTENTIONAL DEPLOYMENT OF MISINFORMATION, SKEWED PROPAGANDA, AND CYBER WARFARE TO DISTORT REALITY AND UNDERMINE INFORMATION SYSTEMS IS REFERRED TO AS "WEAPONIZATION." [7]

WEAPONISATION

- CENSORSHIP
- INTERNET BLACKOUTS
- STEREOTYPING
- DISINFORMATION
- PROPAGANDA
- STRATEGIC SILENCE

HOW SYSTEMIC ERASURE IS EXECUTED?

Applying Evlondo Cooper’s Typology (2025) [4]

1. Silencing

(Barrier to entry)

2. Reclassification
(Renaming "Uprising" to "Riot")

3. Substitution

(Replacing Truth with Narrative)

4. Tactical Forgetting
(Removing chapters)

1. SILENCING:

SUPPRESSION MAY TAKE THE FORM OF EXPLICIT CENSORSHIP, WHERE AUTHORITIES BLOCK PUBLICATION, OR SUBTLER EXCLUSION THROUGH GATEKEEPING AND BIAS [8]

CENSORSHIP

> CENSORSHIP DESCRIBES THE SUPPRESSION, REGULATION, OR CONTROL OF COMMUNICATION AND EXPRESSION BY AUTHORITY, TYPICALLY A GOVERNMENT, WHEN DEEMED HARMFUL, OFFENSIVE, OR THREATENING TO PUBLIC ORDER AND MORALITY [9]
>
> -- RISHABH KANDARI

CENSORSHIP

- PRESS AND REGISTRATION OF BOOKS ACT, 1867
- INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY ACT, 2000
- IT AMENDMENT RULES, 2023
- THE TELECOMMUNICATIONS ACT, 2023
- BROADCASTING SERVICES (REGULATION) BILL, 2024

INTERNET SHUTDOWNS

"AN INTENTIONAL DISRUPTION OF INTERNET OR ELECTRONIC COMMUNICATIONS, RENDERING THEM INACCESSIBLE OR EFFECTIVELY UNUSABLE, FOR A SPECIFIC POPULATION OR WITHIN A LOCATION." [10]

GOVERNMENTS USE SHUTDOWNS AS A TOOL TO CONTROL THE FLOW OF INFORMATION, OFTEN CALLING THEM "KILL SWITCHES." [10]

2. RECLASSIFICATION (RENAMING "UPRISING" TO "RIOT")

SOURCE : WHAT DO YOU SEE IN THIS IMAGE? AN "UPRISING" OR A "RIOT"?
– DAVID GOLDMAN/AP

WHAT DO YOU SEE IN THIS IMAGE?
AN "UPRISING" OR A "RIOT"? [12]

“ INSTEAD OF SUPPRESSING MATERIAL OUTRIGHT, RECLASSIFICATION RELOCATES IT TO A PERIPHERAL DOMAIN, LIMITING ITS EFFECT ON THE DOMINANT NARRATIVE [4]

--EVLONDO COOPER (2025)

3. SUBSTITUTION (REPLACING TRUTH WITH NARRATIVE)

- THE STATE IMPOSES A "SAFE" NARRATIVE TO REPLACE A VIOLENT REALITY. [4]

4. TACTICAL FORGETTING (REMOVING CHAPTERS)

- The deliberate removal of established facts to reshape national identity. [4]
  - e.g: Textbook Deletions

LIBRARIES AS A SITE OF RESISTANCE AND HEALING

PRESERVING MEMORY DURING GENOCIDE AND REBUILDING TRUTH AFTER GENOCIDE

PUBLIC LIBRARY. BERLIN. 1930

(PICTURES NOW, N.D.) PICTURES NOW. (N.D.). PUBLIC LIBRARY. BERLIN. 1930. ALAMY. HTTPS://WWW.ALAMY.COM/PUBLIC-LIBRARY-BERLIN-1930-IMAGE184445400.HTML

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    a. 1950s- Libraries supporting Civil Defense (pro-preparedness phase)
    b. Late 1960s- Libraries begin resisting civil defense (critical phase)
    c. 1980s- Libraries actively promote Arms Control & Peace information (peace-building phase)

WHY LIBRARIES AS A SITE FOR HEALING?

The central role books assume in a society through their creation of collective memory. Like books, monuments are also thought of as agents of memory and representations of the human desire to preserve the past for future generations.

After genocide, communities don’t only need justice, they need spaces to recover memory, rebuild trust, and reconnect socially. Libraries become healing spaces because they are safe, public, and memory-centered institutions.[2]

THE VITAL ROLE OF LIBRARIES IN WARTIME. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026 FROM HTTPS://LITREACTOR.COM/COLUMNS/THE-VITAL-ROLE-OF-LIBRARIES-IN-WARTIME

2. Pearl, M. (2015). Books and Libraries as Witnesses of the Second World War and the Holocaust in Monuments: Vienna and Berlin. In G. Bischof & F. Karlhofer (Eds.), Austrian Federalism in Comparative Perspective (Vol. 24, pp. 151–171).

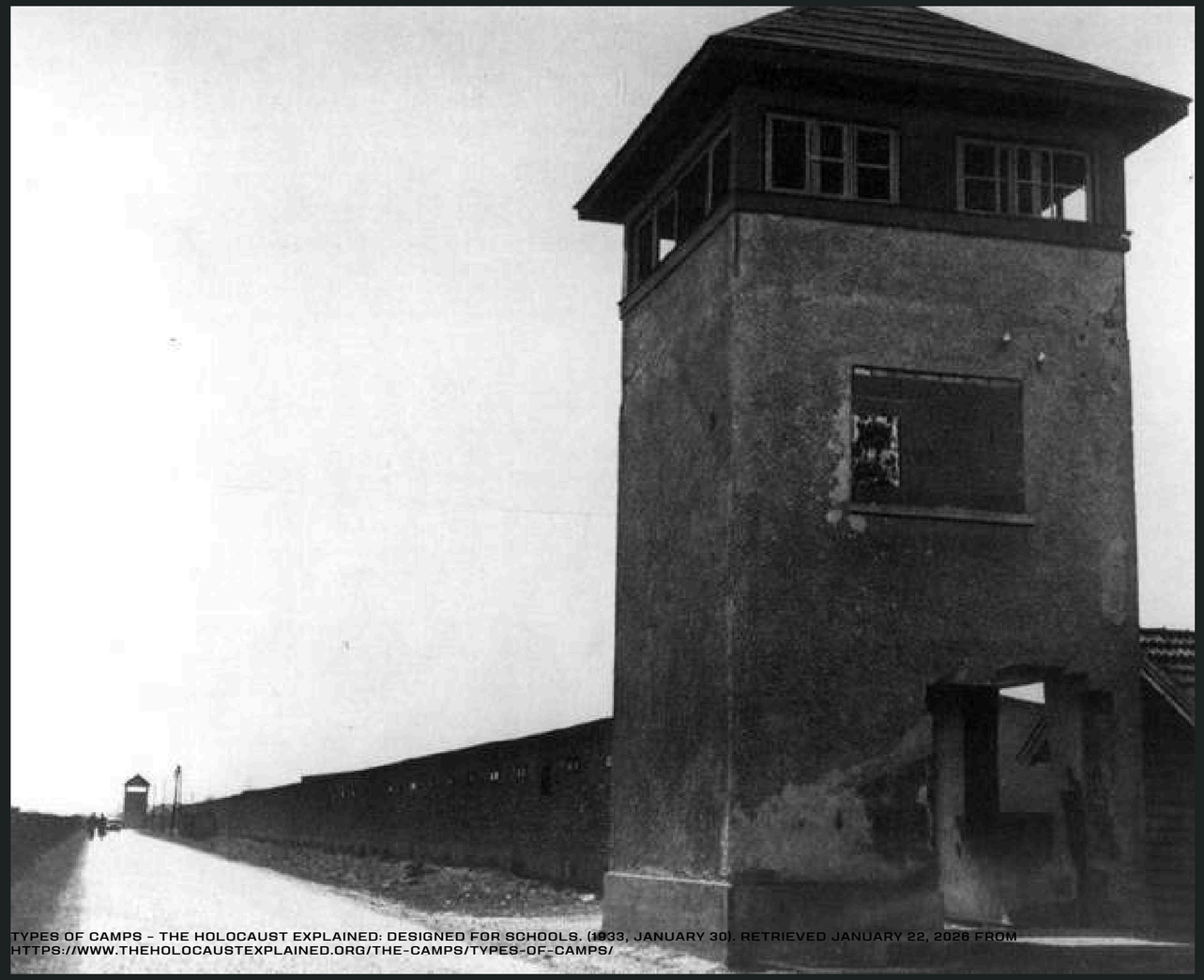
CULTURAL SURVIVAL THROUGH STORAGE MEMORIES

“

As with functional memory, the establishment of storage memory is dependent on being supported by institutions that store, conserve, index and circulate cultural knowledge. Archives, museums, libraries and memorials are part of this task, as well as research departments and universities [1]

-Aleida Assmann, 2009

1. Altanian, M. (2017). Setting the Records Straight: Archives as Guardians of Impartial and Objective Historical Truth? In Archives against Genocide Denialism? (pp. 18–27). Swisspeace.



TYPES OF CAMPS – THE HOLOCAUST EXPLAINED: DESIGNED FOR SCHOOLS. (1933, JANUARY 30). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026 FROM HTTPS://WWW.THEHOLOCAUSTEXPLAINED.ORG/THE-CAMPS/TYPES-OF-CAMPS/

THE WATCHTOWER AT DACHAU. DACHAU WAS CREATED IN 1933 AND WAS ONE OF THE FIRST NAZI CONCENTRATION CAMPS

STORAGE MEMORIES[1]

- Memorial Monuments
- libraries
- Archives
- Memorial Museums

1. Altanian, M. (2017). Setting the Records Straight: Archives as Guardians of Impartial and Objective Historical Truth? In Archives against Genocide Denialism? (pp. 18-27). Swisspeace.

MONUMENT – “NAMELESS LIBRARY”

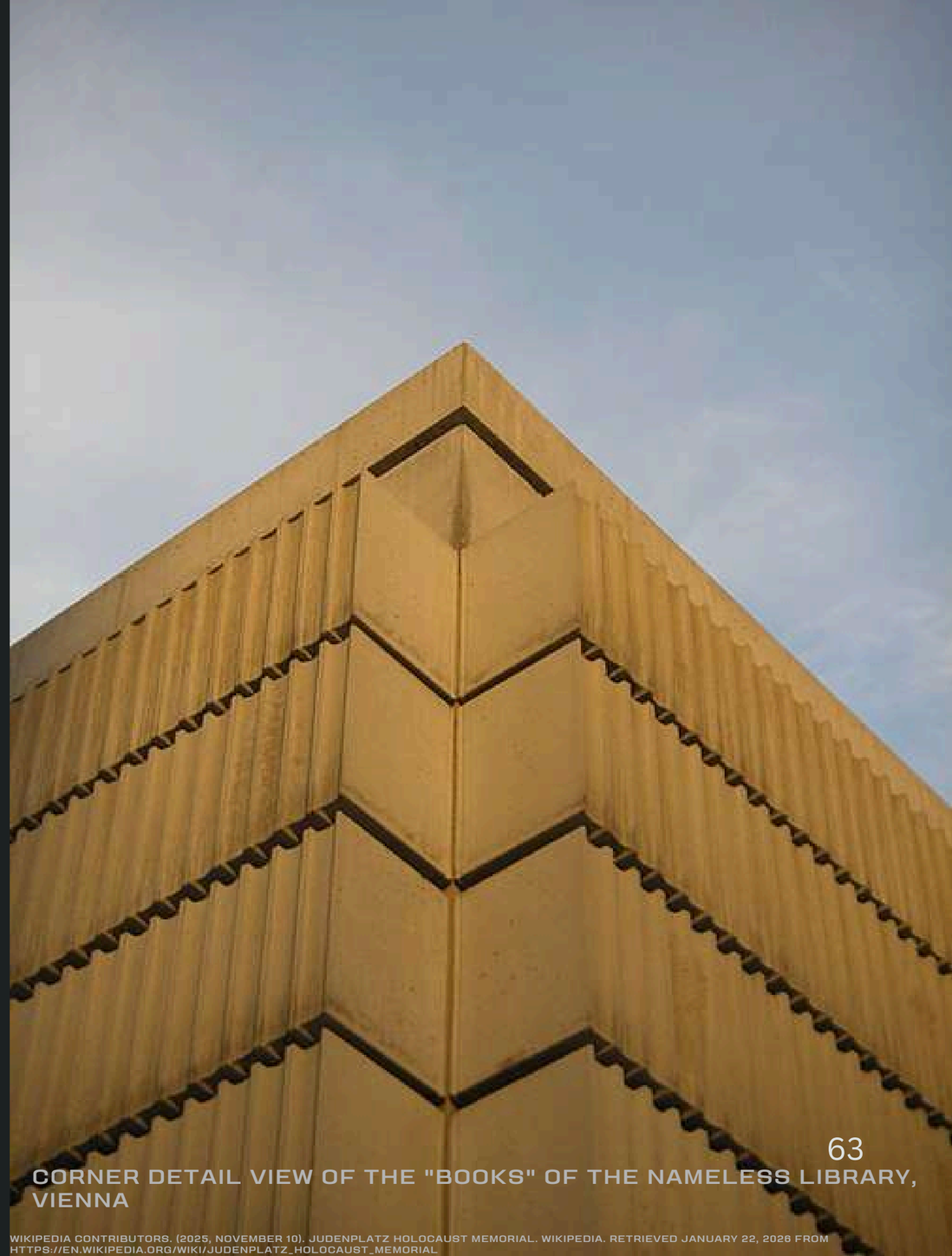
THE JUDENPLATZ HOLOCAUST MEMORIAL

WIKIPEDIA CONTRIBUTORS. (2025, NOVEMBER 10). JUDENPLATZ HOLOCAUST MEMORIAL. WIKIPEDIA. RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026 FROM HTTPS://EN.WIKIPEDIA.ORG/WIKI/JUDENPLATZ_HOLOCAUST_MEMORIAL

“NAMELESS LIBRARY”

-Racheal Whiteread

- The “Nameless Library” was erected to remember the victims of the Holocaust.
- location: Judenplatz, Vienna
- The dimensions create a sense of comfort and contentment at the same time, the “library” also evokes discomfort by means of closed doors, which block the entrance and create a feeling of isolation like a “Bunker” situated in the middle of the square. [2]



CORNER DETAIL VIEW OF THE "BOOKS" OF THE NAMELESS LIBRARY, VIENNA

WIKIPEDIA CONTRIBUTORS. (2025, NOVEMBER 10). JUDENPLATZ HOLOCAUST MEMORIAL. WIKIPEDIA. RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026 FROM HTTPS://EN.WIKIPEDIA.ORG/WIKI/JUDENPLATZ_HOLOCAUST_MEMORIAL

2. Pearl, M. (2015). Books and Libraries as Witnesses of the Second World War and the Holocaust in Monuments: Vienna and Berlin. In G. Bischof & F. Karlhofer (Eds.), Austrian Federalism in Comparative Perspective (Vol. 24, pp. 151–171).

THE INSCRIPTIONS BELOW THE CLOSED DOORS OF THE “NAMELESS LIBRARY”

ENGRAVINGS OF THE NAMES OF THE CONCENTRATION CAMPS AT WHICH THE VICTIMS WERE KILLED, AT THE FOOT OF THE MEMORIAL

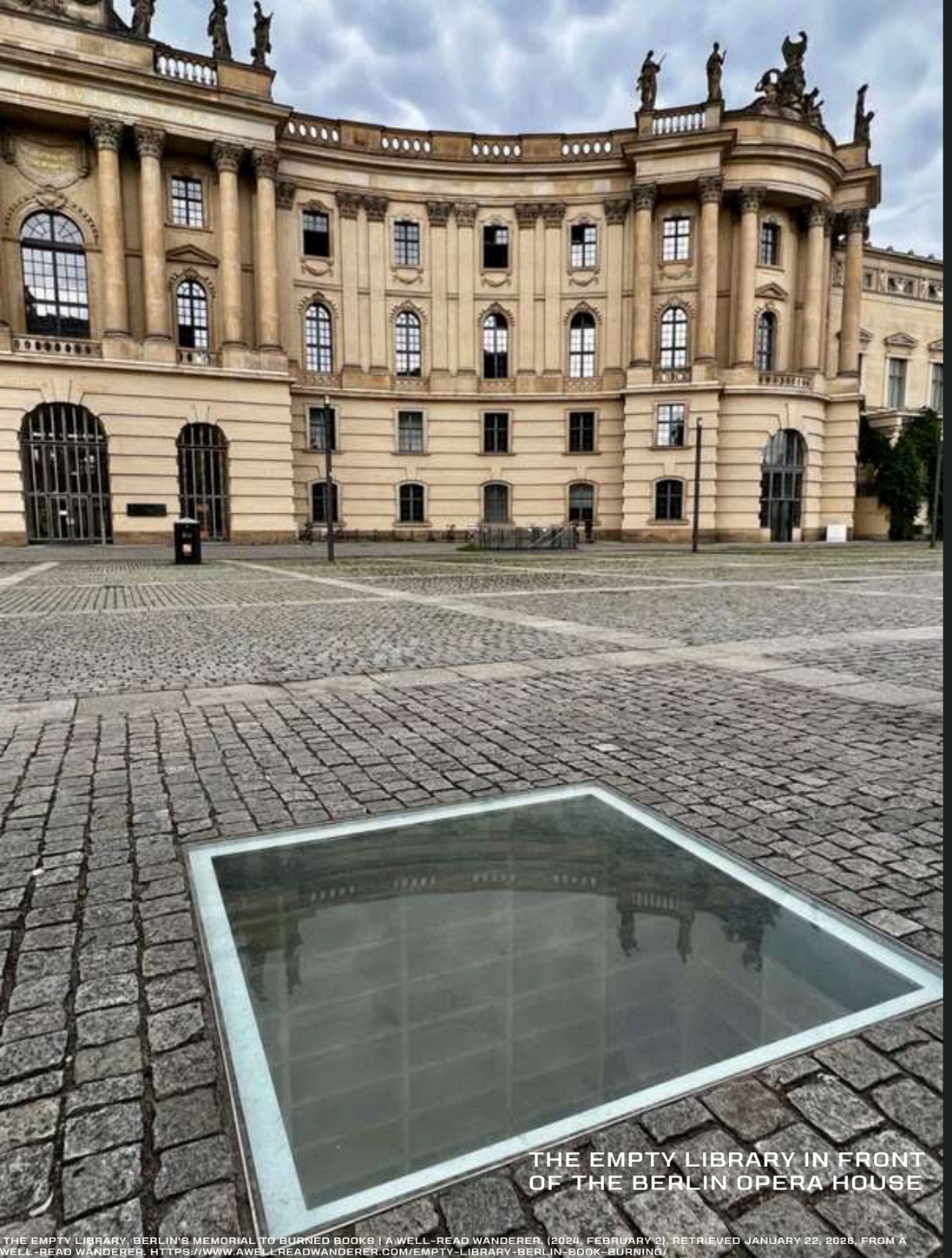
RACHEL WHITEREAD'S JUDENPLATZ HOLOCAUST MEMORIAL, 2000 VIENNA, AUSTRIA. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://DANIELJFULLER.COM/RACHEL-WHITEREADS-JUDENPLATZ-HOLOCAUST-MEMORIAL-2000-VIENNA-AUSTRIA/

2. Pearl, M. (2015). Books and Libraries as Witnesses of the Second World War and the Holocaust in Monuments: Vienna and Berlin. In G. Bischof & F. Karlhofer (Eds.), Austrian Federalism in Comparative Perspective (Vol. 24, pp. 151–171).

MONUMENT– “EMPTY LIBRARY”

THE EMPTY LIBRARY, MEMORIAL TO NAZI BOOK BURNING, BERLIN, GERMANY. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM THE LIBRARY OF CONGRESS. HTTPS://WWW.LOC.GOV/ITEM/2023634301/

A MEMORIAL CREATED IN 1995 BY ISRAELI SCULPTOR MICHA ULLMAN. MORE THAN 20,000 BOOKS WERE BURNED IN MAY 1933 NEAR THE MEMORIAL'S LOCATION AT THE BEBELPLATZ IN THE CENTER OF BERLIN



THE EMPTY LIBRARY IN FRONT OF THE BERLIN OPERA HOUSE

THE EMPTY LIBRARY, BERLIN'S MEMORIAL TO BURNED BOOKS | A WELL-READ WANDERER. (2024, FEBRUARY 2). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM A WELL-READ WANDERER. HTTPS://WWW.AWELL-READWANDERER.COM/EMPTY-LIBRARY-BERLIN-BOOK-BURNING/

"EMPTY LIBRARY"

-Micha Ullman

- The "Empty Library" is an underground space that leaves the surface empty, unlike traditional monuments in public places that attract the spectator through their impressive size.

- The memory of "The Night of the Book Burning" in 1933, which was an emblematic event, whose power demolished freedom of thought, is revealed every time one stops to look at the monument.[2]

2. Pearl, M. (2015). Books and Libraries as Witnesses of the Second World War and the Holocaust in Monuments: Vienna and Berlin. In G. Bischof & F. Karlhofer (Eds.), Austrian Federalism in Comparative Perspective (Vol. 24, pp. 151-171).

“EMPTY LIBRARY” (IN MEMORY OF THE NAZI BOOK BURNING), 1995, CONCRETE, GLASS, AND IRON. BEBELPLATZ, BERLIN

PEDESTRIANS LOOKING DOWN ON THE “EMPTY LIBRARY” AT BEBELPLATZ, BERLIN (IN MEMORY OF THE BOOK BURNING), 1995.

BOOKS AND LIBRARIES AS WITNESSES OF THE SECOND WORLD WAR AND THE HOLOCAUST IN MONUMENTS: VIENNA AND BERLIN.(2015). (VOL. 24, PP. 151-171). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM UNIVERSITY OF NEW ORLEANS PRESS. HTTPS://DOI.ORG/10.2307/J.CTT1N2TXPF.13

LIBRARIES AS “COMMUNITY DEFENSE SYSTEMS” – A WARTIME MODEL

WHAT WAS THE COLD WAR? (2019, MAY 23). BBC NEWSROUND. RETIRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://WWW.BBC.CO.UK/NEWSROUND/47122488

CHURCHILL’S DESCRIPTION OF AN “IRON CURTAIN DESCENDING ACROSS THE CONTINENT” WAS AN EFFECTIVE METAPHOR TO DESCRIBE THE SOVIET UNION’S SPHERE OF INFLUENCE.

THE COLD WAR, CHURCHILL’S IRON CURTAIN, AND THE POWER OF IMAGERY. HISTORY GUILD. (2021, OCTOBER 6). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://HISTORYGUILD.ORG/THE-COLD-WAR-CHURCHILLS-IRON-CURTAIN-AND-THE-POWER-OF/?SRSLTID=AFMBOOODGPCIYH607-UEL1ZVFVPMOI8LSTZJ-DHISST60ZGVA6PMJ9F

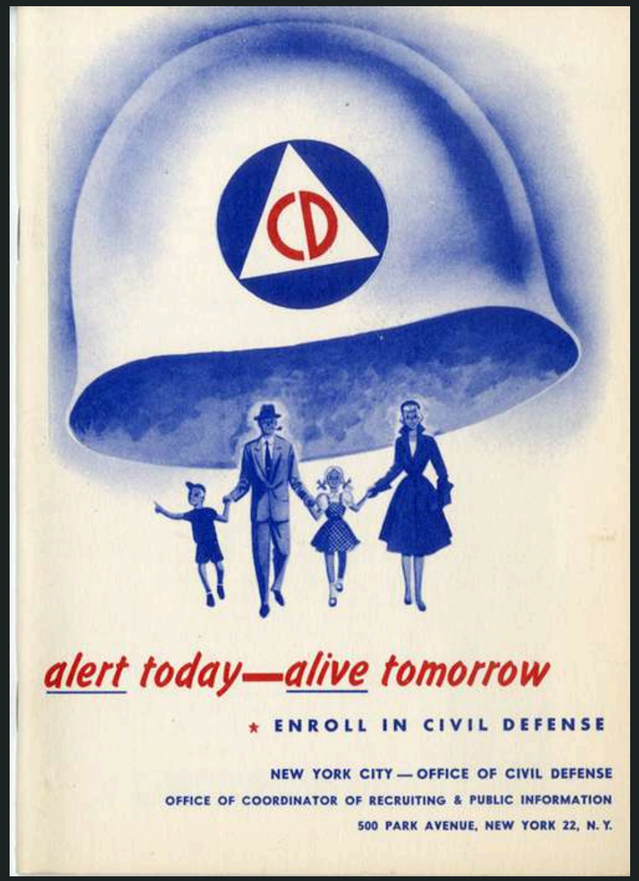
- Many businesses, schools, churches, and libraries served as fallout shelter during the Atomic Age of the Cold war

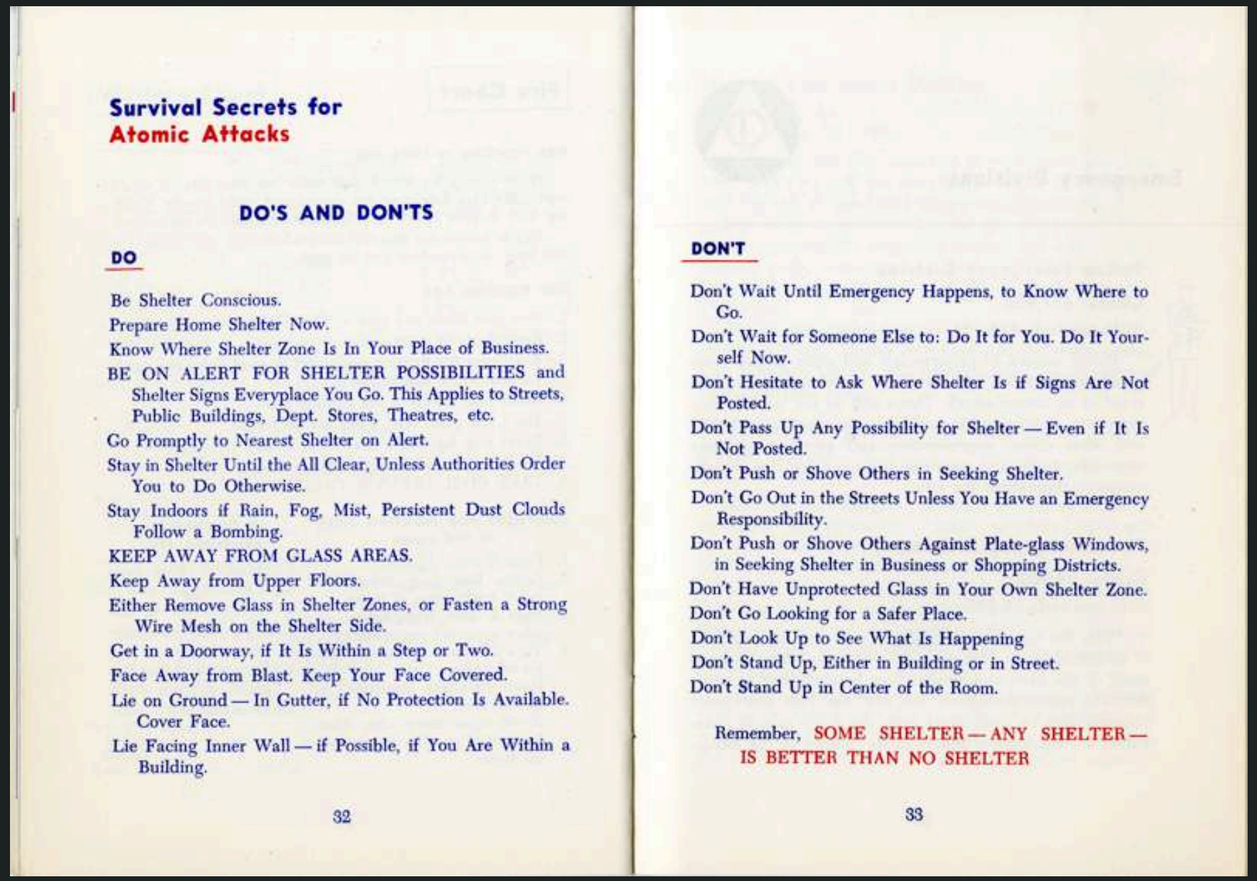
- the main role of libraries during the atomic age
  - fallout shelters
  - disseminating survival information to the public
  - collecting and promoting peace literature [3]

SAN FRANCISCO MORATORIUM PEACE MARCH OCCURRED ON NOVEMBER 15, 1969

NOVEMBER 15, 1969 VIETNAM WAR MORATORIUM
VIETNAM WAR MORATORIUM WORLD WIDE PROTEST. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://ESTUARYPRESS.COM/HRMA-PHOTO-POST/VIETNAM-WAR-MORATORIUM/

3. Spencer, B. (2008). Preparing for an Air Attack: Libraries and American Air Raid Defense during World War II. Libraries & the Cultural Record, 43(2), 125-147.





Survival Secrets for Atomic Attacks

DO'S AND DON'TS

DO

Be Shelter Conscious.
Prepare Home Shelter Now.
Know Where Shelter Zone Is In Your Place of Business.
BE ON ALERT FOR SHELTER POSSIBILITIES and Shelter Signs Everyplace You Go. This Applies to Streets, Public Buildings, Dept. Stores, Theatres, etc.
Go Promptly to Nearest Shelter on Alert.
Stay in Shelter Until the All Clear, Unless Authorities Order You to Do Otherwise.
Stay Indoors if Rain, Fog, Mist, Persistent Dust Clouds Follow a Bombing.
KEEP AWAY FROM GLASS AREAS.
Keep Away from Upper Floors.
Either Remove Glass in Shelter Zones, or Fasten a Strong Wire Mesh on the Shelter Side.
Get in a Doorway, if It Is Within a Step or Two.
Face Away from Blast. Keep Your Face Covered.
Lie on Ground — In Gutter, if No Protection Is Available. Cover Face.
Lie Facing Inner Wall — if Possible, if You Are Within a Building.

32

DON'T

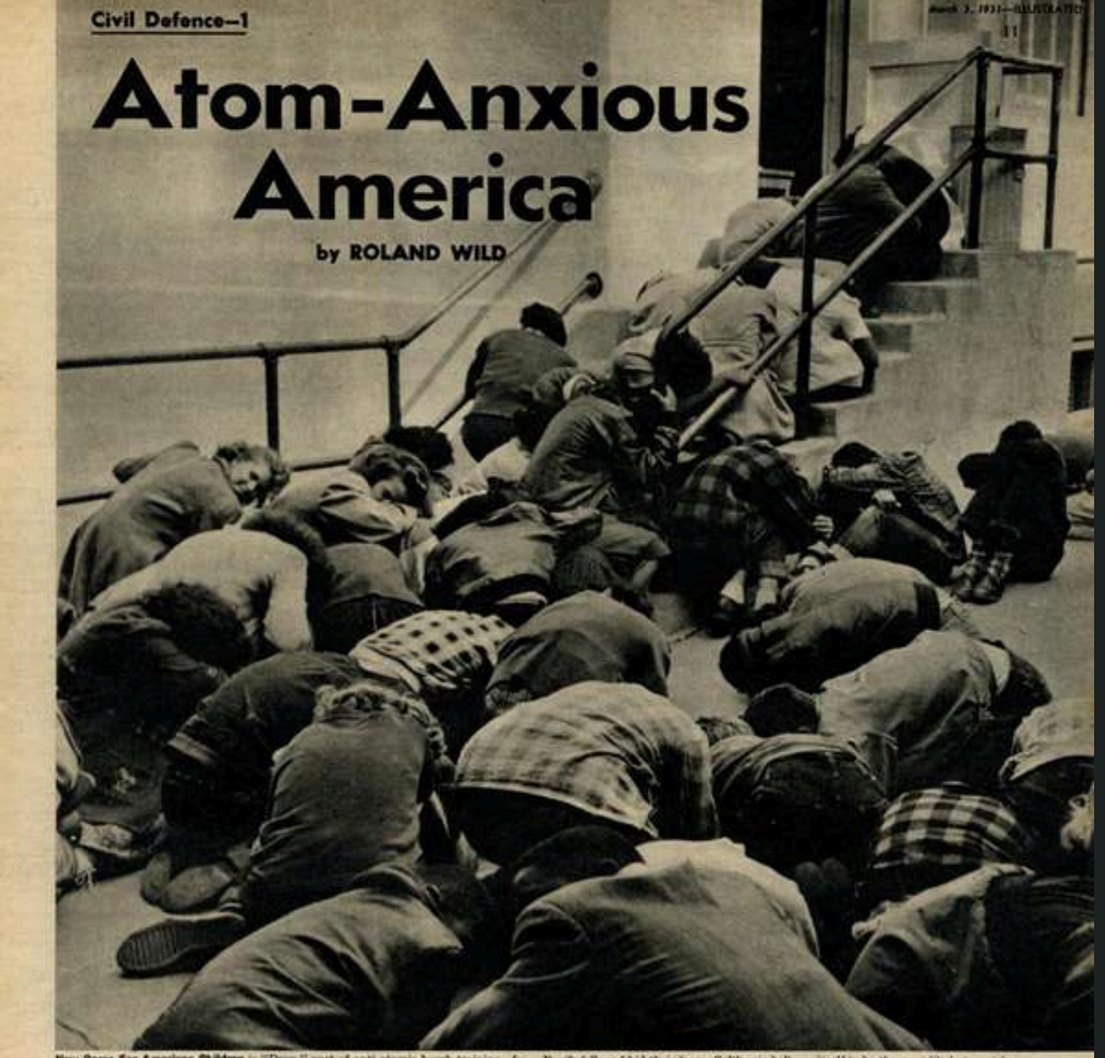
Don't Wait Until Emergency Happens, to Know Where to Go.
Don't Wait for Someone Else to: Do It for You. Do It Yourself Now.
Don't Hesitate to Ask Where Shelter Is if Signs Are Not Posted.
Don't Pass Up Any Possibility for Shelter — Even if It Is Not Posted.
Don't Push or Shove Others in Seeking Shelter.
Don't Go Out in the Streets Unless You Have an Emergency Responsibility.
Don't Push or Shove Others Against Plate-glass Windows, in Seeking Shelter in Business or Shopping Districts.
Don't Have Unprotected Glass in Your Own Shelter Zone.
Don't Go Looking for a Safer Place.
Don't Look Up to See What Is Happening
Don't Stand Up, Either in Building or in Street.
Don't Stand Up in Center of the Room.

Remember, SOME SHELTER — ANY SHELTER — IS BETTER THAN NO SHELTER

33

NEW YORK CITY OFFICE OF CIVIL DEFENSE. EXCERPT FROM "ALERT TODAY – ALIVE TOMORROW", CA. 1952. MCNY. 2017.29.4

CIVIL DEFENSE DURING THE COLD WAR. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM MUSEUM OF THE CITY OF NEW YORK. HTTPS://WWW.MCNY.ORG/STORY/CIVIL-DEFENSE-DURING-COLD-WAR



Civil Defence—1

Atom-Anxious America

by ROLAND WILD

New Game For American Children is "Drop," part of anti-atomic bomb training. In this Los Angeles school a bell rang without warning, to signify a surprise attack. Pupils fell, and hid their faces. California believes itself to be the most likely target for attack. Governor Warren has forecast 100,000 casualties in Los Angeles from one bomb

The United States has begun in earnest to organize for civil defence. At first there was a tendency not to take it seriously, but now the ordinary American has decided that his life may depend on being prepared

KATHY DIMITRO, a pleasant little girl of seven, who, being half Greek and half Irish, was a good American citizen, leaped happily from her school desk in the middle of a lesson and raced downstairs to crouch in the hall, her head buried in her arms and her skirt lifted over her face. The ringing of the school bell had brought down also her neighbours in class—Italian and Negro and Chinese and German—all of whom thought it was a pleasant enough interruption. For two minutes they knelt silently in the big school hall.

Kathy was playing America's newest and grimmest game, "Drop." The rules were laid down by the United States Government's bible on civil defence, *You Can Beat the A-Bomb*, as locally interpreted by the school board.

Kathy, kneeling on the floor with her head under her dress, was no special problem to the people who are planning the defence of the civil population against the effects of the A- or H-bomb, for she was willing to do what she was told without having political opinions about it. The rest of the United States, however, in this year of the Great Alarm, is inclined to make this, like many other chapters of American history, the biggest, fastest, most grandiose epic in the world. It was involving millions of words of advice and millions of dollars on administration, some frantic digging of holes in the ground, signing up of amateur plane-spotters and fire wardens, and a hasty routing out of old tin hats.

Kathy knew none of this, but even some parents of children now lying on the floor made an issue of this very exercise with Dr. John Abbott, chief co-ordinator of defence in the schools, and with George McCoy, vice-principal, and Mrs. Gertrude Smith, a director. Dr. Abbott said: "Some parents actually asked why we should teach children the meaning of war in this way. 'Why not teach them about peace?' they asked."

A NEWSPAPER CLIPPING FROM 1951 ON THE VIEWS OF THE PANIC THAT SET IN THE AMERICAN CITIZENS

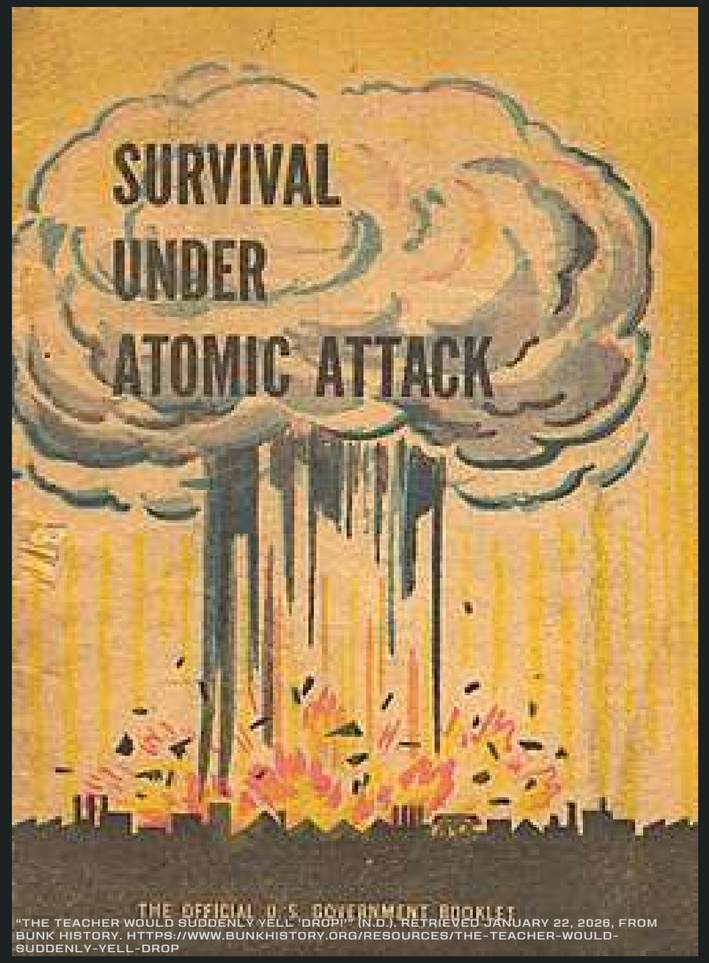
COLD WAR, CIVIL DEFENCE, SHELTERS, DUCK AND COVER. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://WWW.FULLTABLE.COM/VTS/C/COLDWAR/CD.HTM

In the entirety of the cold war that was taking place, the role of the libraries were on three timelines specifically

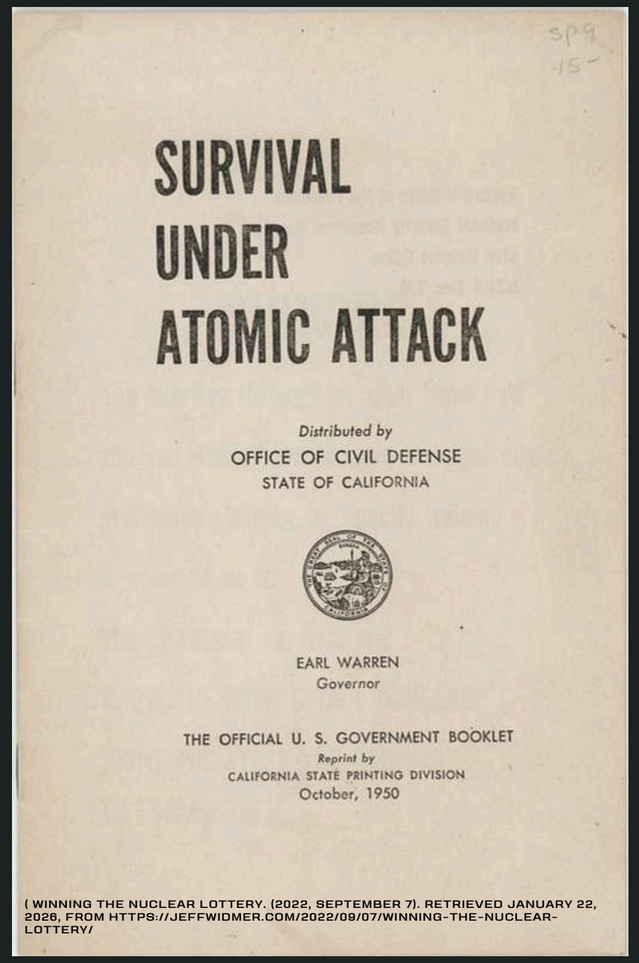
- 1950s- Libraries supporting Civil Defense (pro-preparedness phase)
- Late 1960s- Libraries begin resisting civil defense (critical phase)
- 1980s- Libraries actively promote Arms Control & Peace information (peace-building phase) [3]

3. Spencer, B. (2008). Preparing for an Air Attack: Libraries and American Air Raid Defense during World War II. Libraries & the Cultural Record, 43(2), 125-147.

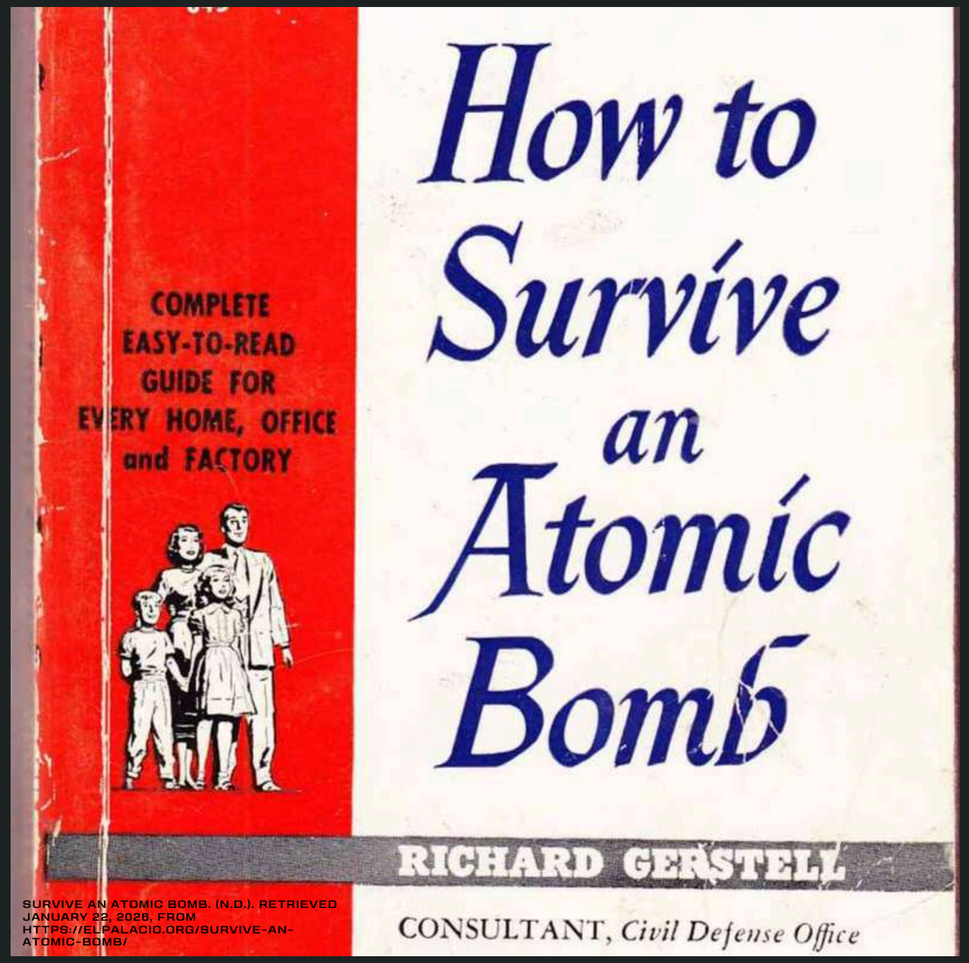
1950S– LIBRARIES SUPPORTING CIVIL DEFENSE (PRO–PREPAREDNESS PHASE)



"THE TEACHER WOULD SUDDENLY YELL 'DROP!'" (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM BUNK HISTORY. HTTPS://WWW.BUNKHISTORY.ORG/RESOURCES/THE-TEACHER-WOULD-SUDDENLY-YELL-DROP



(WINNING THE NUCLEAR LOTTERY. (2022, SEPTEMBER 7). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://JEFFWIDMER.COM/2022/09/07/WINNING-THE-NUCLEAR-LOTTERY/



SURVIVE AN ATOMIC BOMB. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://ELPALACIO.ORG/SURVIVE-AN-ATOMIC-BOMB/

POSTERS AND BOOKS ISSUED DURING THE ATOMIC AGE AS AN INSTRUCTION TO SURVIVE THE ATOMIC BOMBING OR ATTACK BY THE LIBRARIES THAT SUPPORTED CIVIL DEFENSE

LATE 1960S- LIBRARIES BEGIN RESISTING CIVIL DEFENSE (CRITICAL PHASE)

CIVIL DEFENSE DURING THE COLD WAR. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM MUSEUM OF THE CITY OF NEW YORK. HTTPS://WWW.MCNY.ORG/STORY/CIVIL-DEFENSE-DURING-COLD-WAR

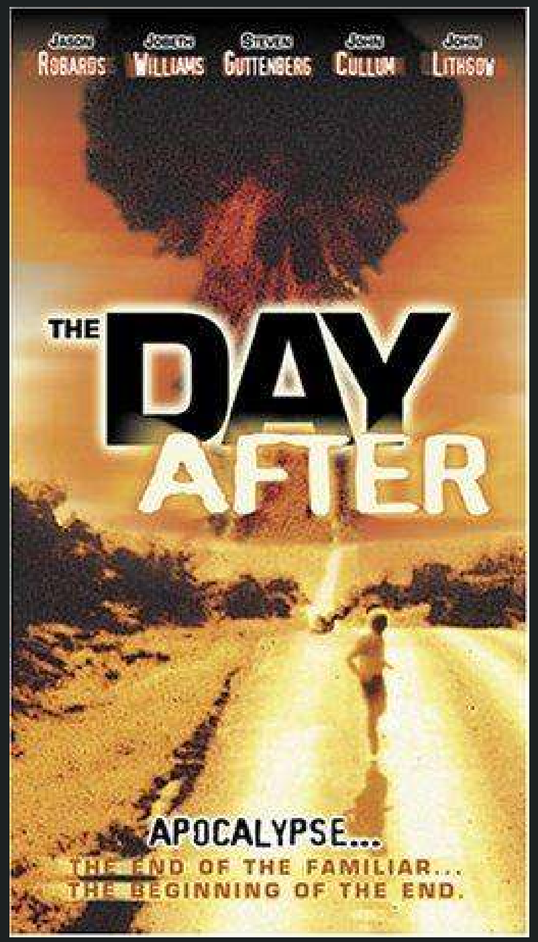
THE DURHAM FAMILY REHEARSES WHAT IT WILL DO IF AN ATOMIC BOMB BLASTS THEIR NEIGHBORHOOD

NOVEMBER 15, 1969 VIETNAM WAR MORATORIUM VIETNAM WAR MORATORIUM WORLD WIDE PROTEST. (N.D.). RETRIEVED JANUARY 22, 2026, FROM HTTPS://ESTUARYPRESS.COM/HRMA-PHOTO-POST/VIETNAM-WAR-MORATORIUM/

SAN FRANCISCO CONTINGENT OF THE WORLDWIDE PROTESTER AND THEIR BANNERS. LABOR UNION LOCALS, TEACHERS, STUDENTS, LIBRARIANS, ENGINEERS, SCIENTISTS, DOCTORS AND HEALTH WORKERS ALL CARRIED BANNERS PROTESTING THE WAR IN VIETNAM, 1961

1980S– LIBRARIES ACTIVELY PROMOTE ARMS CONTROL & PEACE INFORMATION (PEACE-BUILDING PHASE)

PEACE ACTIVISTS IN EUROPE RALLIED AGAINST THE BASING OF NUCLEAR WEAPONS ON THE CONTINENT, IN THE US, ACTIVISTS RALLIED AROUND AN IDEA: A BILATERAL HALT (OR “FREEZE”) TO THE ARMS RACE



“THE DAY AFTER“(1983) MOVIE POSTER - BASED ON THE ATOMIC BOMBING DURING COLD WAR

ETHICS AND CENSORSHIP

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Censorship & information control
2. Ethical Responsiblity
3. Documentation and Recordkeeping as Evidence of Genocide
4. Preventing Genocide Denial

CENSORSHIP & INFORMATION CONTROL

Censorship during genocide is not simply about restricting access; it is about deciding whose history is allowed to exist.

- Genocidal regimes systematically use libraries and archives to remove, destroy, or delegitimize the records of targeted groups, transforming information professionals into instruments of ideological control. [1] [2]

- Historical research shows that book purges, archival seizures, and reclassification practices were embedded in state policy, contributing directly to the erasure of a community’s intellectual and cultural life.[2]

SOURCE:JOYCE ZHANG

[1] Valencia, M. (2002). Libraries, nationalism, and armed conflict in the twentieth century. Libri, 52(1), 1–12. https://doi.org/10.1515/LIBR.2002.1

[2] Grimsted, P. K. (2005). Roads to Ratibor: Library and archival plunder by the Einsatzstab Reichsleiter Rosenberg. Holocaust and Genocide Studies, 19(3), 390–458. https://doi.org/10.1093/hgs/dci034

CENSORSHIP & INFORMATION CONTROL

- Some librarians complied under authoritarian pressure, continuing “routine” professional work that ultimately enabled historical erasure .[1]

- Others engaged in forms of resistance. Documentation of library losses later enabled restitution efforts, while contemporary librarians have hidden books and digitized collections under occupation to preserve cultural memory [2][3]

[3]Gosart, U. (2025). Ukrainian libraries under Russian occupation: Censorship, destruction, and resistance. Journal of Documentation, 81(3), 675–695. https://doi.org/10.1108/JD-01-2024-0021

ETHICAL RESPONSIBILITY

- LIS scholars argue that neutrality can function as moral disengagement, allowing professionals to avoid responsibility while injustice continues[4][5]
- Dudley [6] demonstrates that even technical practices such as classification and subject headings are value-laden and can reinforce dominant, denialist narratives.
- Professional bodies such as IFLA have condemned attacks on libraries during armed conflict, signaling that ethical engagement—not neutrality—is expected in such contexts[7][1]
- In more recent conflicts, professional statements supporting libraries under attack have framed librarians as essential workers and cultural defenders, emphasizing ethical responsibility to preserve memory and resist information warfare[3]

[4]BRanum, C. (2008). The myth of library neutrality. Progressive Librarian, (31), 1–10
[5]WEnzler, J. (2019). Neutrality and its discontents: An essay on the ethics of librarianship. portal: Libraries and the Academy, 19(1), 55–78. https://doi.org/10.1353/pla.2019.0004
[6]DUDLEY, M. Q. (2017). A LIBRARY MATTER OF GENOCIDE: THE LIBRARY OF CONGRESS AND THE HISTORIOGRAPHY OF THE NATIVE AMERICAN HOLOCAUST. INTERNATIONAL INDIGENOUS POLICY JOURNAL, 8(2), ARTICLE 6. HTTPS://DOI.ORG/10.18584/IIPJ.2017.8.2.6
[7]KAGAN, A. (2009). ETHICS, LIBRARIANSHIP AND THE INTERNATIONAL RESPONSIBILITY OF THE PROFESSION. IFLA JOURNAL, 35(3), 191–199. HTTPS://DOI.ORG/10.1177/0340035209346210

DOCUMENTATION AND RECORDKEEPING AS EVIDENCE OF GENOCIDE

Documentation is a prerequisite for justice.

- Archival records enable war crimes prosecutions, truth commissions, and reconciliation processes, while their absence enables impunity [8]
- In Cambodia, classification and metadata revealed ethnic targeting, directly supporting genocide convictions [9]
- In contrast, Zimbabwe’s suppression of archival records related to the Gukurahundi massacres has delayed justice and sustained trauma [10]

[8]Gilliland, A. J. (2014). Conceptualizing twenty-first-century archives. In A. J. Gilliland, S. McKemmish, & A. Lau (Eds.), Research in the archival multiverse (pp. 31–61). Monash University Publishing.

[9]Caswell, M. (2012). Using classification to convict the Khmer Rouge. Journal of Documentation, 68(2), 162–184. https://doi.org/10.1108/00220411211209106

[10]Khumalo, N. B. (2018). Silence, erasure, and denial: Archives and the Gukurahundi genocide in Zimbabwe. Archival Science, 18(3–4), 1–21. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10502-018-9295-5

PREVENTING GENOCIDE DENIAL

Genocide denial often operates through silence, euphemism, and barriers to discovery.

- Dudley [7]shows how library classification systems have contributed to the denial of Indigenous genocide by failing to name it explicitly.
- Ghaddar [11] describes archival erasure as necessary for sustaining a “historical lie,” while other cases demonstrate how destroying cultural institutions aimed to deny a multiethnic past [1]
- Social media spreads coded hate, emotional manipulation, and false narratives that normalise violence before atrocities escalate[12]
- UNESCO and IFLA position libraries as essential institutions for building media and information literacy in conflict-affected societies [13]

[11] Ghaddar, J. J. (2025). Palestine as provenance: Archiving against genocide from Gaza to South Lebanon (Jabal Amil). Archival Science, 25, 1–22. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10502-024-09490-2

[12]Kārkliņš, J. (2011). Towards digital literacy: What libraries can do. UNESCO / IFLA World Library and Information Congress.

[13]Nayab, D., Nasir, S., Yaqoob, K., & Bashir, A. (2025). Decoding language of social media platforms on genocide: A critical discourse analysis of Gaza war posts. The Critical Review of Social Sciences Studies, 3(2), 979–986.

Holland House Library, London, after a German air raid in October 1940.

Holland House Library – London 1940 – ARTNL. (n.d.). https://artnl.org/?product=holland-house-library-london-1940

CUSTODIANS OF TRUTH

CONCLUSION

- *Genocide is not limited to physical violence; it also involves the* ***systematic destruction of knowledge, memory****, and* ***cultural identity****.*
- *Libraries, archives, and information institutions are deliberate* ***targets*** *in genocidal campaigns because they* ***preserve a people’s history, language, and existence.***
- *Historical case studies demonstrate that attacks on libraries often precede or* ***accompany mass violence,*** *validating the warning that “where they burn books, they burn people.”*
- *Cultural and indigenous knowledge systems are especially vulnerable, and their destruction leads to* ***irreversible loss of non-documented histories.***

CONT.

- *In the digital age, **burning a library may not involve fire**—but the result is the same.*
- *Archives and library collections serve as evidence for truth, justice, and accountability, playing a crucial role in **post-genocide tribunals** and reconciliation processes.*
- *Librarians and information professionals are **not neutral actors**; they are **ethical custodians** responsible for protecting marginalized voices and historical truth.*

Rogers, J. , & Petrarca, D. (2014, December 7). And the sword in the stone (Season 1, Episode 1) . In J. Rogers, M. Wright, & P. DeMeo (Executive Producers), The Librarians. Electric Entertainment; TNT.

LIBRARIANS MUST SHIFT FROM BEING ***PASSIVE CUSTODIANS*** TO ***ACTIVE PROTECTORS*** OF CULTURAL MEMORY, ESPECIALLY IN CONFLICT-PRONE CONTEXTS

DISASTER PREPAREDNESS & RISK PLANNING

Preservation research emphasizes that disaster preparedness—covering fire, armed conflict, and civil unrest—significantly reduces damage to library collections. Emergency planning is now seen as a core professional responsibility, not an optional activity

A disaster, whether natural or man-made is "an event whose timing is unexpected and whose consequences are seriously destructive" (Hilda Bohem, "Disaster Prevention and Disaster Preparedness", Berkeley, CA, 1978). Libraries and archives need to make every effort to prepare themselves for possible disasters, by analysing their own situation and resources, and devising a disaster preparedness plan (note that there may be many sections of this plan; later in these guidelines reference is made to the disaster reaction plan, but it is all part of the same planning process).

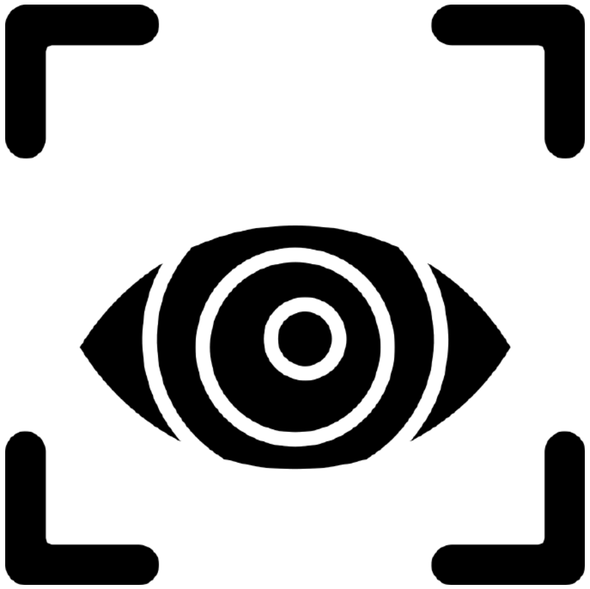
The basic concept of a disaster preparedness plan is to

- minimize risks so far as possible
- maximise the efficiency of response if a disaster occurs.

IFLA (2016), IFLA Disaster Preparedness and Planning : a brief manual, IFLA Core Activity on Preservation and Conservation

CAPACITY BUILDING

A systematic review of literature highlights a growing skills gap in handling preservation during crises. Librarians must be trained not only in technology, but also in ethical documentation and conflict-sensitive information management.



LIBRARIES ARE WITNESSES

“

“WHERE THEY *BURN BOOKS*, THEY WILL, IN THE END, *BURN PEOPLE*.”

— HEINRICH HEINE (1821)

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THANK YOU!